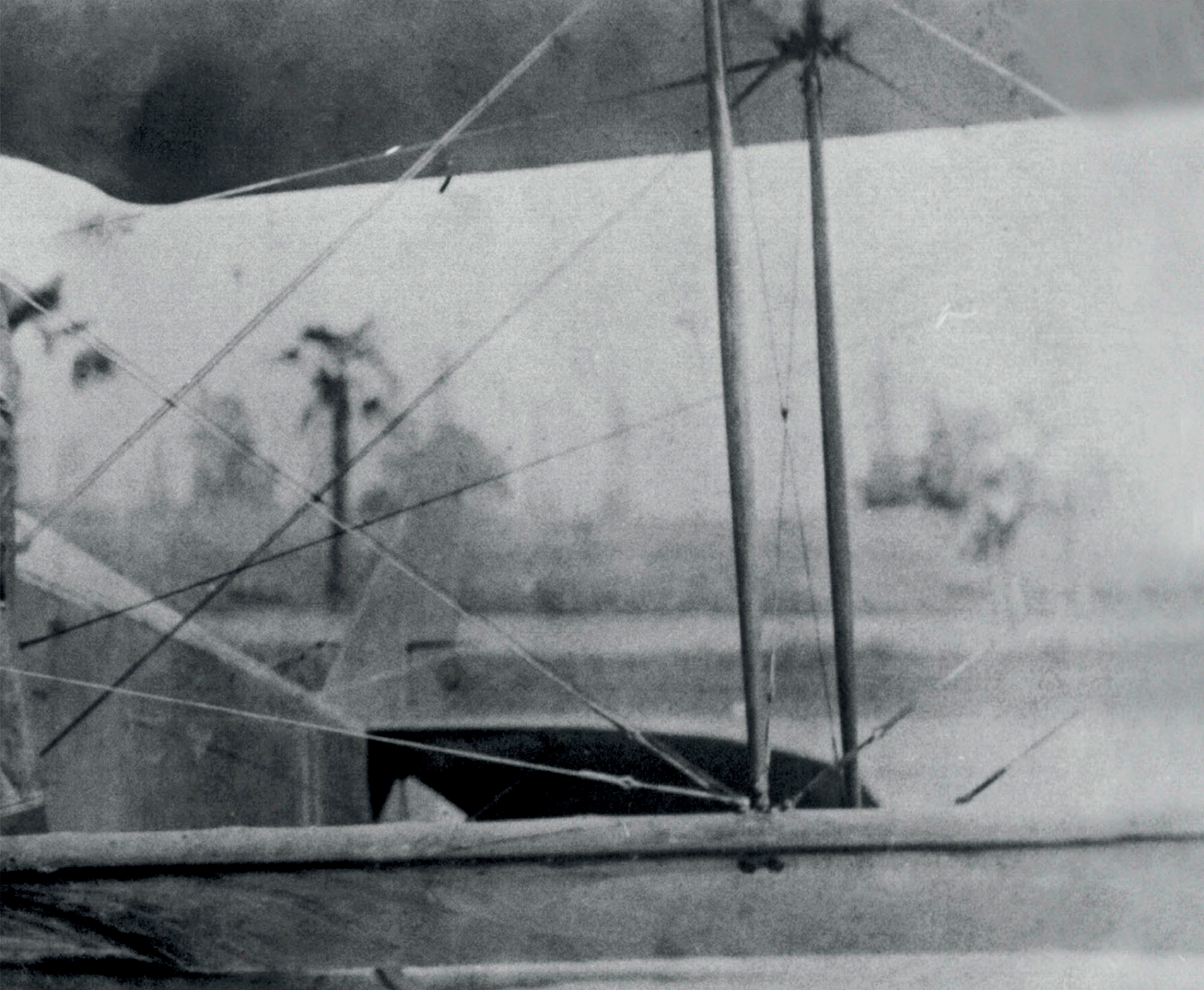




Bessie Coleman

On June 15, 1921, Bessie Coleman (1892–1926) became the first Indigenous and African American woman to earn a pilot's license. The racial climate in the US meant that she was unable to train in her home country and had to travel to France to do it. Coleman was supported by the Black-owned *Chicago Defender* newspaper and sponsored by African American banker Jesse Binga. She was well aware of her role as a pioneer for the Black community and was quoted as saying, "I knew we had no aviators, so I thought it my duty to risk my life to learn."

AVIATION'S QUEEN BESS

Coleman did not just learn to fly, she undertook extra training in Europe to fly "stunts"—the hazardous and spectacular aerobatic flying that was the staple of America's barnstorming shows of the 1920s. Quickly gaining reputation as a skilled and daring exhibition pilot on her return to the US, the self-styled

"Queen Bess" flew Curtiss "Jennies" (JN-4 biplanes) and other surplus WWI airplanes. Coleman's show flying was a means to an end: what she really wanted to do was establish her own flying school.

Tragically, fate intervened on April 30, 1926, when a mechanic's spanner carelessly left under the seats of her newly purchased Jenny jammed the airplane's controls. Coleman and her promoter and mechanic, 24-year-old William D. Wills, died in the subsequent crash. Ten thousand mourners attended her funeral ceremonies. In 1929, the Bessie Coleman Aero Club was founded to continue to promote African American involvement in the world of aviation.

Coleman stands on the wheel of a Curtiss JN-4 "Jenny" in her custom-made flying suit. This photograph, one of the few existing depictions of Coleman, was taken in around 1924.